

WALL OF WATER

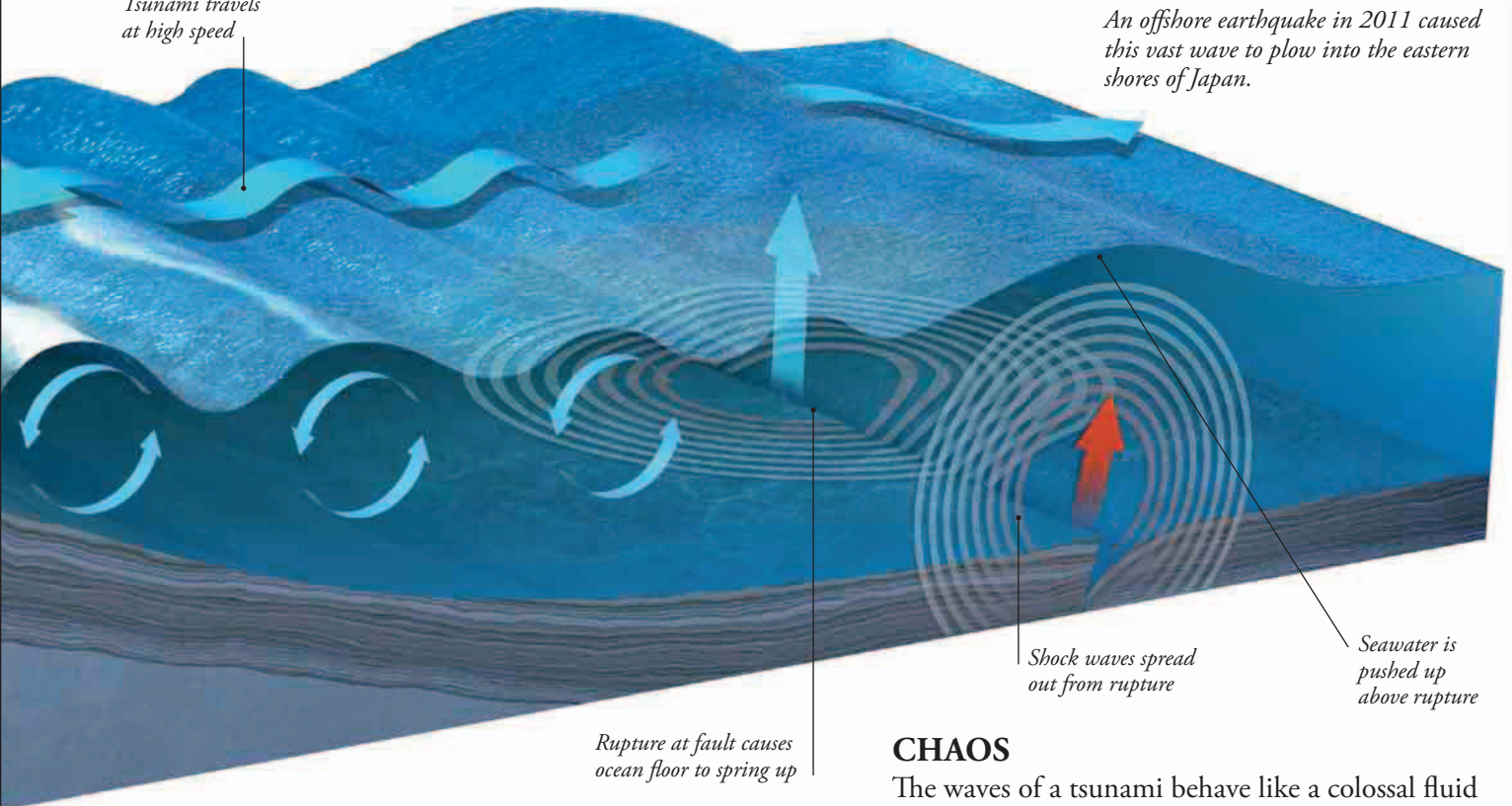
A tsunami is not like a giant version of an ordinary ocean wave. It has a very long wavelength, which means that it takes many minutes to pass, rather than a second or two. It seems to rise like an extra-high tide, and plows ashore like a vast step in the ocean that can completely drown the landscape.



Tsunami travels at high speed

▲ SWEPT AWAY

An offshore earthquake in 2011 caused this vast wave to plow into the eastern shores of Japan.



Rupture at fault causes ocean floor to spring up

Shock waves spread out from rupture

Seawater is pushed up above rupture

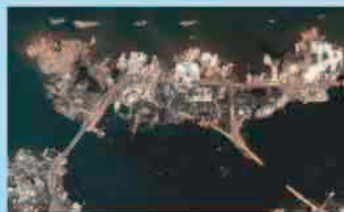
INTERNATIONAL DISASTERS

Tsunamis can travel vast distances, crossing oceans and devastating communities. In 2004, an earthquake in the Indian Ocean off the west coast of Sumatra, Indonesia, caused a tsunami that killed more than 230,000 people living on the shores of 14 countries.

Before



After



▲ DEVASTATED DISTRICT

This district of the city of Banda Aceh on the Sumatran coast was ripped apart by the devastating tsunami of 2004.

CHAOS

The waves of a tsunami behave like a colossal fluid bulldozer, trashing everything in their path. The water gets loaded with floating debris that adds to its destructive power and makes it more deadly—any people caught up in the chaos are unlikely to survive.

